

presentation of a politically-correct Budget, in an election year at that.

For nearly two decades now, coalition governments have ruled at the Centre, but never has the schedule of governance been as confused since the minority Congress began depending on the crutches provided by the Left for sustenance. With its largest-ever contingent in the Lok Sabha, the Left never failed to flex its muscles at the slightest opportunity. It held to ransom legislations aimed at pushing through economic reforms. It blocked

same phrase to describe the National Rural Employment Guarantee (NREG) scheme, which the Congress leaders have been promoting as their party's flagship programme, reluctant to give credit to Rural Development Minister Raghuvansh Prasad Singh of RJD, who is widely seen as the scheme's genuine custodian, or the Left, whose insistence largely led to its implementation. Now, the Congress's image enhancement among poor farmers has posed a serious challenge to the Left's claim of being the sole spokesperson of the poor

and his politburo colleague Brinda Karat say that inflationary trends in the economy and the messy public distribution system are issues that should not have been ignored by Chidambaram. The Left is searching desperately for something wrong in the budget. Says the CPI(M) Politburo, "It does not seem likely that crucial commitments for peoples' welfare made in NCMP (National Common Minimum Programme) can be met."

Retorts Congress MP P.J. Kurien, "Their (Left parties) job is to take credit



SITARAM YECHURY, CPI(M) LEADER

“Two-thirds of the farmers have borrowed money from private money-lenders. Most suicides take place among them.”



VIKRAM SHARMA

vital foreign policy initiatives and its leaders made no efforts to hide their glee when the government sank to its knees. With the elections approaching, the Congress took the only road available—address the election market and possibly seek re-election earlier than scheduled. After greeting the waiting queues of farmers at 10 Janpath on February 29, Congress President Sonia Gandhi called the initiative "revolutionary and historic".

Three years ago, she had used the

LAST HOPE : Left and UNPA leaders at a farmers' rally in Delhi

and marginalised in India. Like the Left, its new-found stable mates in UNPA too had laboured hard to woo this section of society.

In some debt-ridden villages, the cheers are still to die down for the finance minister. Although a large section of poor farmers who borrow from individual money-lenders will not benefit from the loan waiver, the Congress has made a start. Yechury

for whatever good we do but when something goes wrong they blame us."

Having stepped on the gas, the Congress is in no mood to take its foot off the pedal. It has therefore revived discussions on the Indo-US nuclear deal with its UPA allies, eager to close negotiations over India-specific safeguards agreement at IAEA. Why now, ask Left leaders. The answer from the Congress is simple: there could not be a better time to allow the Left to withdraw its support to the Government. Problems between the Left Front's CPI(M) and the smaller parties persist and the grand old party knows the art of fishing in troubled waters.

It is at times like these, say leaders of the smaller Left parties, that they miss the political acumen of someone like former CPI(M) general secretary H.K.S. Surjeet who, unlike his successor Karat, might have been able to salvage the situation. The Left's options now are clearly limited. One being the third alternative along with TDP, SP, NC, INLD, AGP and JMM but that would only be the last resort. Unfortunately for the Left, this seems to be the only option left. ■

If money grew on trees...

your future plans would become a little 'To do' list.